



Maybe not so sweet

LG's latest Chocolate Touch claims to have integrated Dolby sound. It comes with a full HTML browser and easy access to Facebook and MySpace



Saygus VPhone

The Android-based handset is said to be able to deliver video calls at up-to 30fps on EDGE 2.5 networks and might open up the video calling market in the US in the near future

Feature



Channels featured on peoplesound.com

Then and now...

The next format in which action is heating up presently is voice offerings, which start with the same kind of content that you get on the other platforms. Operators have their IVR menus and their individual numbers. You have third-party content providers that offer their own content in this space too. Voice services include chat, dating (which is basically voice chat put to some interesting use), blogs and marriage services.

The voice products offered by Mobile2Win have seven million registered users across operators. This shows that the average consumer is hooked.

Mobile communities are another area that have just taken off in India in a big way. Not surprising that according to Opera Mini's state of mobile web report for August 2009, the mobile versions of sites such as Orkut.com, Facebook.com and Peperonity.com (a mobile-based social networking web site) figure high among the top ten. Mygamma.com also seems to be popular in this space. The rudimentary versions of mobile networks started coming up some time back when colleges and academic interest web sites such as pagalguys.com had their own SMS networks to disseminate important alerts to students.

Communities even on mobile format are all about social networking and collaboration. The mobile platform adds a touch of ubiquity to social networking which is already popular on the web. A natural outcome of such communities

is the huge amounts of user generated content, be it in the form of pictures, video, recommendations, reviews, and topsites. Many companies are going into the social networking play in a big way after realising the opportunities here. Nazara has just announced a tie up with New York-based mobile social community called Cellufun.com. Much of the content on cellufun will now be offered by Nazara through various operators. Cellufun appears to be something like a SecondLife, but in the mobile format. People socialise,



Simone Ranucci Brandimarte
Co- CEO & COO, Buongiorno

“The next level of mobile telephony is ‘entertainment on the go’. Services are the key growth drivers, and it will be extremely important to customise offerings to target user demands”



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buy virtual goods for self expression, gifting, and for competitive advantage all in a game-centred environment.

Another popular mobile social network is peoplesound.com launched by Buongiorno. It lets you update status messages and follow topic specific channels. mobile2win.com is also looking to enter this space in a big way with its soon-to-be-launched product that will combine user generated video content and social networking. "We at mobile2win are in the market right now pitching couple of new products which will be available with Indian as well as international operators. One of the products is going to be a UGC video product, and our friends chat product which we're taking to the international market," informs Hiranandani.

Gaming is perhaps the most popular and most consumed form of mobile entertainment in the country. We all like the distraction offered by mobile games on the seemingly long and endless commutes that many of us in the urban setting have

to endure daily. According to a research conducted last year the Indian mobile gaming industry alone is worth around \$40 million a year. This accounts for about half of the electronic gaming market across all platforms including consoles, handhelds and PC. Naturally, we will be seeing significantly better offerings with game sizes moving up from a few KBs to multiple MBs. Perhaps turn-based MMORPGs (massively multiplayer online role playing games) may be the next big step on the mobile platform.

Cutting edge innovations

The value of content was identified long ago and there have been many innovative initiatives launched by content providers, networks and even handset manufacturers in an effort to gain the attention of consumers. Early on, there were some failed experiments with content delivery mechanisms. For instance, the Hungama.com-backed MobileMagic initiative announced a scheme in 2007, through which you could buy memory cards loaded

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with legal content. Users could recharge their card with content such as movies, ringtones, songs, games and wallpapers through retail partner tie-ups with Cafe Coffee Day outlets. The premise was that it's difficult to download rich content due to the limitations of GPRS. It failed.

A while ago, Reliance launched a scheme by which novels would be delivered to consumers via SMS. The first novel doled out was “Deaf Heaven”, and was sent to subscribers through a total of 90 SMSs over a period of thirty days. Reliance also planned to make the book available as an audio book — at a cost of one rupee a minute. The audio book was 60 minutes long and the cost of subscribing to the service was Rs. 30. It's an interesting viral way for books to be promoted, but we're still not sure how many people will be comfortable with reading / listening to books on their cell phone.

Other interesting things happening in the mobile entertainment space are more contemporary than others. Bharti Airtel recently tied up with twitter to bring the power of microblogging updates to the masses by bringing it down to the SMS